territorial claims such as described by the author have multiplied. For example, the South China Sea is claimed as China's 'historic waters', following the same logic. Sperling also points out that this latest narrative-building would seem to 'allot no place to independent Mongol history and to ascribe to certain areas that are today under India, such as those in Arunachal Pradesh, only a Chinese history since time immemorial'.

The implications of how China projects its expansive territoriality to the world need to be carefully studied and contested. Without such vigorous contention, the Chinese narrative, no matter how outrageous, begins to take hold in international discourse as something 'self-evident'. Chinese propaganda then begins to assert these positions as being 'well known' and therefore, by definition, legitimate.

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What do we learn from this complex and often confusing history of China–Tibet relations?

One, until the occupation of Tibet by PRC troops in 1950, Tibet was never under the direct rule of any Han or non-Han empire ruling China. Even when it was part of the non-Han Mongol Yuan and the Manchu Qing empires, it enjoyed both secular and religious autonomy. Under these dynasties, it was part of these empires, just as China itself was. In 1912, after the fall of the Qing dynasty, the thirteenth Dalai Lama declared Tibet's independence but failed to obtain de jure international recognition.

Two, the tenuous claim that Tibet has been part of China at least since the Yuan dynasty has created a legitimacy dilemma for the Chinese state, which accounts for its acute sensitivity concerning Tibet's status and its insecurity concerning the loyalty of the Tibetan population. The fact that even sixty years after the Dalai Lama's exile in India he is still revered in Tibet is a constant source of anxiety. The history of intimate cultural and religious relations between India and Tibet and the presence in India of the Dalai Lama and a large community of Tibetans create an enduring Chinese suspicion that India may become the agency for the undermining of its rule in Tibet. Several efforts made by the Dalai Lama to seek reconciliation with